



HANGING FIRE...

Some of the ambitious projects that are either stuck or have been aborted

↘ **IT park:** The BJP government announces a Rs 20 crore plan for an IT park in 1998. The Agra Development Authority hands over 2.5 acres of land in Shastripuram to the Software Technology Parks of India. Construction yet to be completed

↘ **Civil terminal:** In 2015, as part of the Regional Connectivity Scheme, a new civil terminal is proposed to be built at Kheria Airport at a cost of Rs 400 crore. Lack of clearance from the Union environment ministry and the Taj Trapezium Zone Authority forces Airports Authority of India to drop the plan

↘ **Leather park:** The BSP government lays its foundation on the Agra-Jaipur highway in 2015. The construction at a cost of Rs 100 crore is to be completed in two years. Land acquisition starts, but after TTZA's intervention, project's put on hold

↘ **High court bench:** Justice Jaswant Singh Commission constituted in 1981 to assess demand to set up a high court bench in western UP. Agra district is found suitable for the bench. Nothing heard since

↘ **Potato Processing Unit:** The then SP government announces the setting up of a potato processing unit and research centre for farmers in 2015. The horticulture department earmarks 10 ha in Signa. The Rs 100 crore proposal, sent by the state to the Centre, is still stuck

↘ **Heliport project:** PM Modi lays the foundation for the Rs 4.95 crore project on January 9, 2019. Construction work between Inner Ring Road and the Agra-Lucknow Expressway in Madra was to be finished in Oct. 2020. Non-receipt of funds means it will be done in 44 months. Cost has escalated to Rs 7.9 crore

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ON HOLD (Clockwise from far left) The proposed site for a rubber check dam on the Yamuna; the abandoned Mughal Museum-turned-Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Museum; the unfinished IT Park at Shastripuram; a statue of Maharana Pratap waiting to be unveiled



Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

tiles in the seminar hall—now serving as a shelter for stray dogs—have come off in several places.

Presiding over this abandoned landscape is a bright yellow banner fluttering at the gate, announcing the structure's new name—the Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Museum. And rather than documenting any Mughal splendour, the renamed structure will display the history of the Braj Mandal, where Lord Krishna is believed to have been born and spent his childhood and adolescent years.

Ever since the BJP government took charge in the state, the demand to change the names of the roads, parks, monuments etc. in Agra has increased exponentially; some have already been renamed (see *What's in a Rename?*). Former BJP MLA Jagan Prasad Garg has written to the chief minister seeking the renaming of Agra to Agravan. On May 4, deputy chief minister Keshav Prasad Maurya, while inspecting the metro project work, directed the officials to rechristen the Jama Masjid station Mankameshwar, on the suggestion of G.S. Dharmesh, the BJP MLA from Agra Cantt.

The BJP government has also renamed a large number of roads and parks to raise its political capital. The famous Mughal Road in Kamla Nagar is now Maharaja Agrasen Road, since last November. On January 6, just before the 2022 assembly election, the government issued an order to rename Teramauri, the 76-acre state park in Fatehpur Sikri, to Gokula Jat Park, to woo the Jat voters. A life-size statue of Gokula Jat is also being erected here.